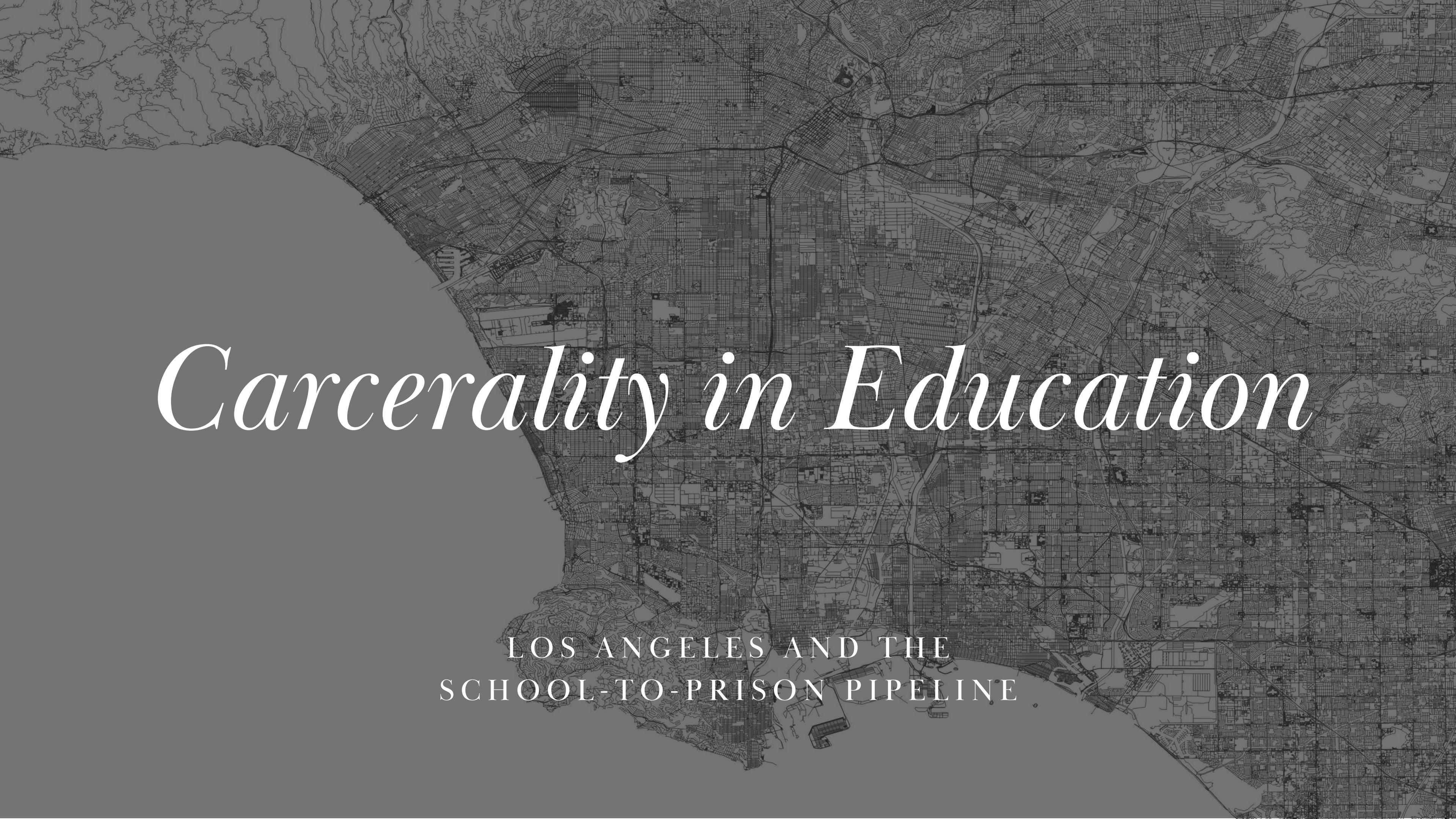




Carcerality in Education

LOS ANGELES AND THE
SCHOOL-TO-PRISON PIPELINE

Research question

What do the historical and contemporary
manifestations of carcerality in Los Angeles
public schools reveal about political
possibilities for abolition?

Background and Context

The School-to-Prison Pipeline

- Racialized criminalizing in schools
- “Enclosure” framework – not unidirectional but rather embedded experiences of correctional ideologies
- Historical evolution, corresponding to societal carcerality and technological developments (ex. metal detectors, security cameras, suspensions, police on campus, “zero tolerance” discipline policies)
- Discipline as a modality of anti-Black racial governance, connected to carcerality in other institutions

Los Angeles Unified School District

- Changing racial demographics post WW2, entrenched segregation, white flight, LAPD governing the War on Crime and maintaining the racial boundaries of the city
- Ideological construction of youth of color as uniquely criminal to justify violent crackdowns
- 1965 Watts Uprising → expansion of security in schools, closer relationship between schools and criminal justice agencies for funding
- 1968-1969 student-led protests, focused on self-determination and community control of schools

Theoretical

Ruth Wilson Gilmore

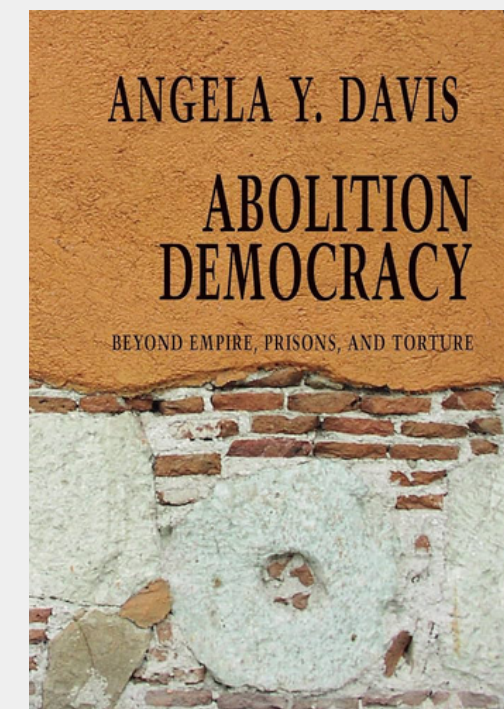
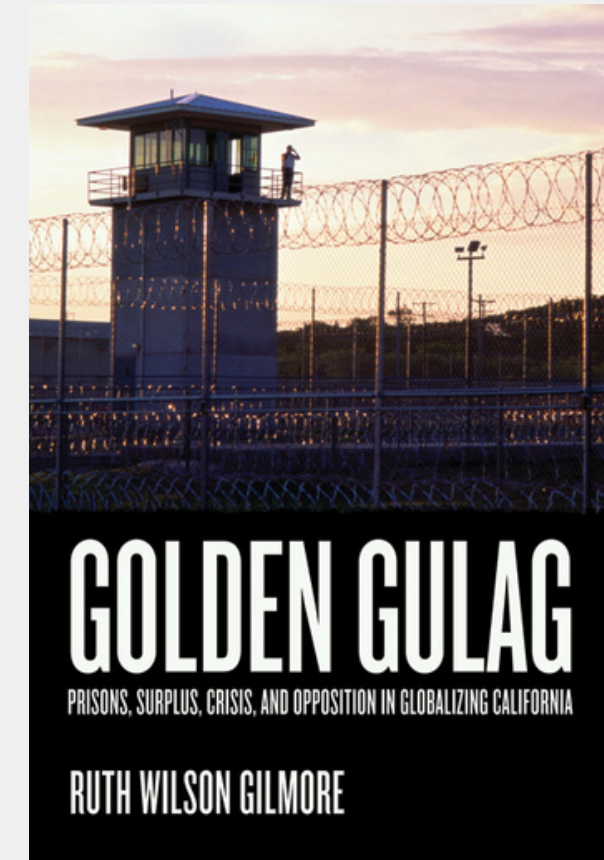
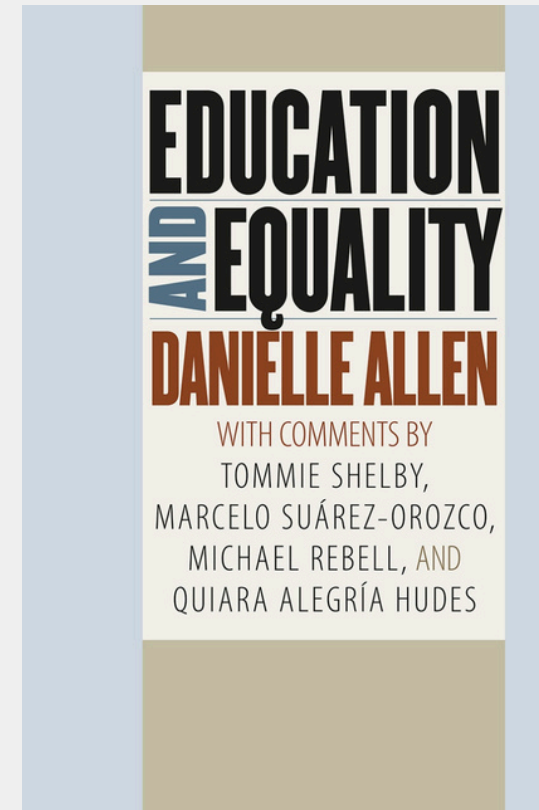
- Prison expansion in California – geographic analysis
- Economic conditions of surplus and crisis
- Racial capitalism

Danielle Allen

- Importance of education to democratic life, and thus to justice
- Education should be oriented away from carcerality, and towards participatory readiness

Angela Davis

- Abolition democracy – negative abolition of carcerality and positive construction of new arrangements and free possibilities (education, land, health care, leadership, etc.)





Susan Miller Dorsey High School

Baldwin Hills

- Mei-Ling Nomusa Malone, 2011
- Comparative historical analysis of prisons, criminal laws, and school discipline policies and student interviews

Student interviews related to police presence on and around campus, changing over the decades from 80s to 90s to 00s – increased policing and increasingly negative student perception.

By 2000s, majority discussed police harassment, racially profiling, abuse, intimidation, use of pepper spray and mace, random searches, unjust arrests, and physical assault.

"You had police officers in uniform, and police with their dogs and in their cars. On the campus and around campus, everywhere. They come into classrooms. They check lockers and put us on lockdown every so often. No one can go in and no one can go out. They use the uniform to scare us, it's intimidating. And they have a school police office on campus. And so now we're dealing with actual police officers, there is no dean to come and break up the fight. They are the first people you deal with when something happens."

Monica, 00s interviews

F.R.E.E. L.A. High School

South Central

- Margaret Goldman, 2024
- Taught at FREE LA for 4 years, conducted 2.5 year ethnography, Gilmore critical geographic approach to FREE LA's specific deliberate departures from carcerality and student experiential insights

School policies: refusal to allow police on campus, abolitionist legal clinic (providing court support for students who get arrested), transformative justice → theorizing care as unconditional. free from state-imposed regimes of surveillance, rooted in the well-being of other humans, against the individual as the basis of liberal democracy, abolition not as perfection but as experimentation

"It's a circle. You don't get suspended. I feel like they teach you to actually deal with your fuckin' problems and not just distance you... Once we had the circle things became more open, we heard each other's side and after that... things aren't just great but... It gets better... There's not animosity anymore. They do a lot of things different that I will say I've never had in a different schooling."

Emani, student



Next steps

1. Historical background, comparative analysis – relationship between criminalization in and outside public education
2. Malone and Goldman's research findings – what do they reveal about carceral and democratic politics within their respective school sites? Student insights?
3. Putting specific insights into conversation with theoretical frameworks – what do these findings suggest about the politics of place in LAUSD? Furthermore, what might they reveal about possibilities for the present/future in the direction of abolition democracy?